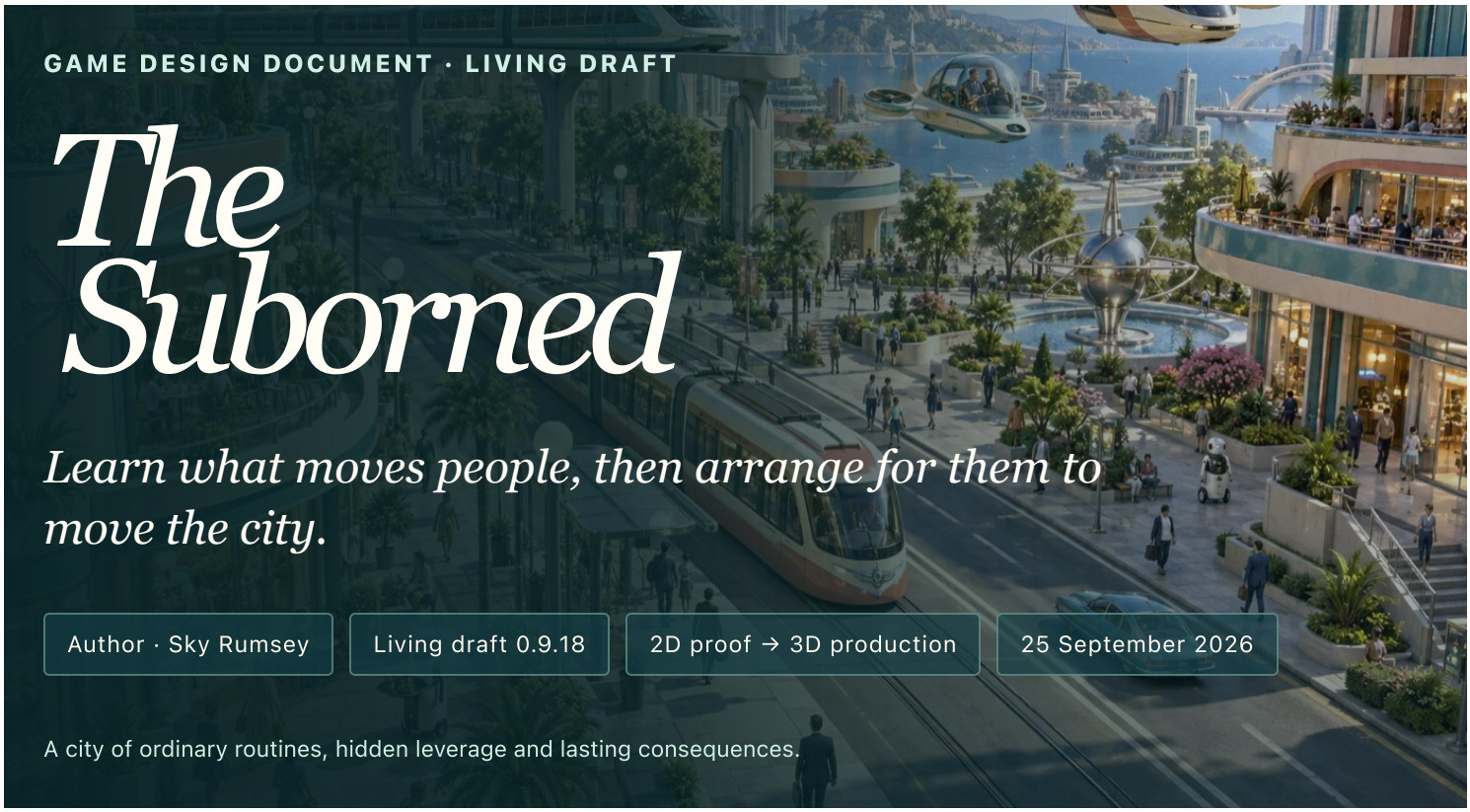


GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT · LIVING DRAFT

The Suborned

Learn what moves people, then arrange for them to move the city.

Author · Sky Rumsey | Living draft 0.9.18 | 2D proof → 3D production | 25 September 2026

A city of ordinary routines, hidden leverage and lasting consequences.

Influence moves the world.	DISCOVER **Subvert** What moves a person?
COORDINATE **Orchestrate** Who can move the city?	REMEMBER **Adapt** What changes afterwards?

Premise. In a retrofuturist city, a covert faction pursues aims that may be altruistic or ruthless. Its operatives suborn ordinary people, then use their jobs and relationships to reach others. The player can approach ten people directly or persuade two contacts to approach the rest, trading personal exposure for time and a traceable chain.

First proof. One visible operative must extract a restricted Records Office routing ledger. The 2D browser build tests a direct request and a civilian relay; later missions add a four-person field team. Anima agents build the game. Authored rules run it.

01

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The city is the instrument

A real-time social infiltration game about making people move the city for you.

PILLAR 1

Subvert

Find a person's motive and earn, buy or force a specific commitment.

PILLAR 2

Orchestrate

Link contacts, access and schedules into a live chain of actions.

PILLAR 3

Adapt

Handle refusal, exposure, fading influence and remembered treatment.

02

GAME MECHANICS

Seed a chain, stay unseen

One embodied operative starts the operation; citizens extend its reach.

Discover → **Suborn** → **Orchestrate** → **Observe** → **Respond** → **Adapt**

Respond when a plan breaks: reroute through another capable person, escalate to force where the objective permits, or retreat. Extraction completes the mission; detention, lockdown or an exhausted objective ends it clearly. Success, failure and treatment of contacts carry forward.

On screen: move to a clue or person, open a dossier, choose a lever, request and meeting window, then watch the city continue. Patrols, camera sweeps and other people's routines keep moving; the player can hold or abort a request before its handoff. The dossier shows known relationships and confirmed reports, not unseen outcomes.

ONE OBJECTIVE · TWO WAYS TO MOVE HAROLD

Direct	Operative → Harold → Ledger	Fast · must clear patrol and camera
Relayed	Operative → Café worker → Harold → Ledger	Slower · meeting can be watched or interrupted

CHARACTER DIRECTION

People with jobs and leverage

The operative, Harold, the worker and the guard read by occupation before dialogue. Each has access and risks the others lack.



Rules the prototype must implement

SYSTEM	TECHNICAL RULE	PLAYER CONSEQUENCE
Citizen	Job grants actions and access; known relationships define possible relays.	Harold can carry a ledger; the café worker can ask Harold, but cannot enter the archive.
Influence	Resolve an authored approach against motive, trust, risk and remembered treatment.	Harold may accept help with debt, reject a threat or explain a refusal.
Request	Store source, recipient, action, pretext, meeting window, deadline and provenance; queued → en route → meeting → accepted/refused/reported. One relay maximum.	The player can hold or abort before handoff; Harold may still refuse when the worker arrives.
Simulation	Advance routines, patrols, camera sweeps and meetings on one clock; save event times. Nearby people navigate, off-screen people advance by schedule.	Moving a meeting by one patrol cycle can change its outcome; the chain survives reload.
Surveillance	Observers record who, where and when: guard sight lines, a mounted camera's sweep, later covert spies. Footage records presence; a guard or spy can recognise behaviour.	A contact may be safe now but watched seconds later. The player can learn coverage and choose a safer window.
Exposure	Save sightings and reports with source, identity and reporting delay. A lead starts a search; evidence linking the operative to the ledger can seal the archive.	Indirect contact reduces sightings, but a reported chain can still identify the faction's operative.

First mission · Records Office

The block contains the office, café, tram stop, Harold, the café worker, a patrolling guard and a fixed camera. Learn Harold's debt at his collector meeting, then choose whether and when to approach him or send the worker. The worker's meeting may fall inside the camera view or the guard's patrol; the player can hold the request, wait for a gap or move to draw the guard away. Harold can carry the ledger to the tram, but he may leave for another duty before the handoff.

Win: leave the block with the ledger. **Lose:** detention, a security report linking the operative to the ledger reaching the archive before extraction, or Harold becoming permanently unavailable. A suspicious sighting starts a recoverable search; camera footage gains meaning when security checks it. The save records contact treatment, timed requests and the source of each lead.

PoC limit: both approaches share Harold to isolate delegation. His loss triggers explicit failure and restart; the PoC has no combat route. Full missions add another capable actor and may offer force when it can still achieve the objective.

Mission viability rule: each full mission starts with two independent ways to supply the needed capability. After any lasting player action, the remaining state must offer a route, retreat, or explicit failure. Force is an authored, costly escalation, not a universal solution; a build-time reachability check flags silent dead ends.

Later escalation example: the player asks a capable contact to subdue a guard and take their weapon. Willingness, position, timing and witnesses determine whether they try and what follows. Failure may injure or expose the contact; success leaves an unarmed guard and a traceable weapon, drawing security attention. The player chooses what to do with that opening.

03

AI ARCHITECTURE · BUILD-TIME STUDIO

The Anima Atlas crew

Development agents make the game; the player and citizens use authored runtime rules.

BUILD PIPELINE · OUTSIDE THE GAME

Aster brief → **Design · art · build** → **Latch validates** → **Suture tests** → **Aster accepts**

Anima retains agent history and live handoffs. Five roles build the first slice; the wider studio stays dormant until a concrete artifact needs it. Gameplay makes zero model calls.

ACTIVE POC AGENT	DECISION IT OWNS · BOUNDARY	REQUIRED OUTPUT → ACCEPTANCE CHECK
Aster LEAD	Sets scope, resolves conflicts and accepts milestones; does not author the work it reviews.	Versioned brief.md + acceptance-log.md → each feature has one owner and a passed gate.

ACTIVE POC AGENT	DECISION IT OWNS · BOUNDARY	REQUIRED OUTPUT → ACCEPTANCE CHECK
Motive GAME DESIGN	Owns the first mission, capability routes, NPC motives, influence and surveillance rules, and authored responses; cannot invent unbudgeted capabilities.	mission.json + rules.json + dialogue.json → timing, refusal, retreat and failure have readable causes.
Glyph 2D ART	Owns the city graphic kit, character sprites, props and UI artwork; Motive sets gameplay needs, Latch sets import limits.	Sprite atlas + map and UI assets → camera view, patrol direction and known leads read at top-down scale.
Latch ENGINEERING	Owns the Phaser scene, deterministic NPC simulation, UI integration, canonical IDs and save schema; cannot silently change Motive's rules or Glyph's art.	schema.json + validator + playable Phaser build → timed events and explicit terminal states work after reload.
Suture INDEPENDENT QA	Owns uncoached playtests and code/data review; reports defects but does not accept its own fixes.	qa-report.md with reproducible defects → bad early choices yield recovery, retreat or clear failure.

Later specialists, activated by need: Keel (separate data contract), Fable (dialogue volume), Waymark (more missions), Pulse (simulation scale), Splice (tooling), Redline (engineering review), then Vela (Blender environments), Forma (characters), Glint (lighting/effects) and Chime (audio) for the 3D slice. Each takes one artifact from its current PoC owner under a new brief.

Operating rule: Latch signs schema and import changes; Motive signs mechanics and mission changes; Glyph signs sprite and graphic changes; Suture reviews but never closes its own findings. Aster accepts only after a playable check and resolves cross-role conflicts. Pillar changes, new spending and release decisions escalate to Sky Rumsey. Opus 5.5 covers lead and design; Sol 6 covers art production, engineering and review.

04

TECHNICAL STRATEGY · COURSE PILLARS

A playable block in week one

Phaser proves the rules quickly; the same authored data can later move to Unity 3D.

AI development pipeline

Five active roles: versioned artifacts → validation → uncoached route test → Aster's acceptance.

Technical constraint

IDs and capability routes must agree with the mission graph; invalid references or silent dead ends block the build.

Token budget

About 90K for this GDD pass; 4–7M through Week 2 and 8–16M provisionally for five weeks. Gameplay uses zero.

Five-week vertical slice · Week 2 proof gate

Week 1 · playable city block

Glyph prepares the map kit and sprites; Latch authors collision, movement, Harold's routine, direct influence, guard patrol, camera coverage and ledger extraction. Gate: a finishable browser map where contact timing changes detection.

Week 2 · delegated route

Add the café worker's timed request, hold/abort, guard diversion, report delay and saved evidence. Suture repeats the relay at two times and tests one intervention. Interim gate: each outcome changes for a visible reason.

Week 3 · independent recovery

Add a second person able to supply the ledger, an explicit retreat, and a coarse mission-state audit for dead ends. Gate: losing Harold leaves a viable route or a clear mission end.

Week 4 · costly escalation

Prototype one delegated force attempt against a guard as a bounded request, with refusal, success, failure, witnesses and weapon provenance. This is a state change, not a full combat system. Gate: force opens an option and creates lasting risk.

Week 5 · prove and present

Uncoached playtests, route and save/load fixes, visual and audio feedback, performance pass, and GDD revision. Final gate: a player can finish or knowingly retreat through multiple approaches and explain the consequences.

Cut line: if Week 1 slips, cut ambient vehicles, robots, bespoke animation and street décor. If Week 3 slips, cut the force attempt before cutting the independent route, clear failure or legible surveillance. Covert spies and full weapon combat remain later production work.

Constraint, handoff and API bounds

Biggest risk: build agents invent a relationship or capability the runtime does not contain. Latch owns canonical IDs and validates the catalogue; each agent cites approved inputs; Suture verifies both player paths. Glyph's image layer never defines collision or access.

Before crew activation, Aster verifies the actual Opus 5.5 and Sol 6 model IDs, context windows, rate limits and prices. Build calls are queued and logged by role; gameplay has no network or model dependency. The GDD pass estimate is 71K input + 17.8K output = 88.8K tokens. Weeks 1–2 assume 70–100 substantial sessions; Weeks 3–5 add 80–130. At 45–55K text tokens per session plus 25% rework, the provisional five-week envelope is about 8–16M. Reforecast from measured use at the Week 2 gate; track image generation separately.

Acceptance questions: can an uncoached player time a meeting, change a relay outcome, understand a search, and see recovery or explicit failure after a bad choice? For full missions, does the reachability check find two starting routes and no silent dead end?

05

VISUAL DIRECTION · CONCEPT SHEET

Tomorrow has foot traffic

Bright civic optimism above a covert human network.

The later 3D city keeps the 2D proof's routes, sightlines and social spaces. The cover and character studies establish the visual direction for both versions.

Social spaces

Put the Records Office beside the café and tram stop so a player can watch work, friendship and handoff from one block. A later repair forecourt links technicians to robots.

Materials and UI

Cream curves, teal enamel, coral transit accents, warm glass and chrome. Occupational silhouettes must read from above. Dossiers borrow tickets and route maps; known links, planned requests and confirmed reports look distinct at tactical zoom.

Project retrofuture cityfill concept artwork and design discussions for Subvert → Orchestrate → Adapt, the Records Office proof, and the course's AI development pipeline, technical constraints and token budget. The PoC uses Phaser.